DSEH004 · PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND EMPLOYEE ENGAGEMENT

Do Generations Explain Anything?

Week 8 · Lecture 1 · Mannheim, Costanza, Twenge and the lifespan alternative

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L1 · RATIONALE

Why generations belong in this course

1. **A required outcome**
   CLO 5 asks for multigenerational programs; assessed in Quiz 4 and the End Term.

2. **Belief against evidence**
   Where popular claims outrun research: practice in reading design and effect size.

3. **The theory behind Round 4**
   Segment the mobility gradient without stereotypes, defended on performance grounds.

4. **A thread through the course**
   Links Week 3 needs theory to Weeks 9 to 11 and to all four anchors.

5. **The manager coalition thesis**
   A label is a weak manager's shortcut; good design makes managers know the person.

L1 · COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

BT 2026400 has spent 22.5 years in Quality Control and declines every move. Is that because he is Gen X?

Yes, no, or the question is wrongly posed. Stand in three groups.

Mannheim: a generation is more than a birth year

Generation location

Born in the same period. Necessary, never sufficient: it is only a potential.

Generation as actuality

Exposure to the same formative events in youth creates a shared stratum of experience.

Generation units

Groups inside one generation respond to the same events in different, even opposed, ways.

At Bharat Textiles

A Gen Z label borrowed from US usage assumes formative events a Bhiwandi loom operator and a Bengaluru coder never shared.

Mannheim, K. (1952). The problem of generations. In Essays on the Sociology of Knowledge. Routledge and Kegan Paul (original 1928)

Age, period and cohort cannot all be separated

The identity

Cohort = period minus age

Know any two and the third is fixed. No design can estimate all three effects without an untestable assumption.

Design	Holds constant	Confounds
One survey, one year	Period	Age with cohort
Time lag: same age, different years	Age	Cohort with period
Longitudinal: same people over years	Cohort	Age with period

Costanza et al. (2012) and Twenge et al. (2010) both state this limit of single time point designs

Costanza et al. (2012): what lies beneath near zero

The claim being tested

A generation differs because of shared formative experience, and not only because of age. The meta analysis tests that definition, not the labels.

The pattern, not the headline

No difference in job satisfaction. Boomers somewhat more committed. Millennials moderately more likely to intend to leave. Gen X against Millennials depends on the form of commitment.

The authors' reading

Differences that do appear are more likely due to factors **other than generational membership**, such as age and career stage.

The two findings to remember

Studies disagree on where each generation begins and ends. Targeted generational interventions may therefore not be effective.

Twenge et al. (2010): what was really measured

What was measured

Values about an ideal job, reported at 18, before full time work. Anticipated preferences, not experience of a job.

The theory behind it

Cultural change toward individualism, the Generation Me thesis: each cohort absorbs the culture of its youth.

The pattern

Leisure up and work centrality down. Extrinsic values peaked with Gen X. Intrinsic and social values lower. No rise in altruism, against the press.

The limits

Cohort is confounded with period. Values at 18 may shift at work. One US dataset. The Generation Me thesis is contested.

Twenge, Campbell, Hoffman and Lance (2010), Journal of Management, 36(5), 1117 to 1142; Trzesniewski and Donnellan (2010), Perspectives on Psychological Science, 5(1)

Costanza and Twenge: contradiction or complement?

Question	Costanza et al. (2012)	Twenge et al. (2010)
Construct	Attitudes to one's current job	Values about an ideal job
Design	Mostly one time surveys	Time lag at age 18
Confound left	Age with cohort	Period with cohort
Stereotype it rejects	Young workers less satisfied	Young workers more altruistic
What it leaves open	Whether stage explains the gaps	Whether values survive work

Even Twenge's largest difference, d = 0.57, leaves 78% of the two distributions overlapping.

L1 · THE RIVAL THEORY

The lifespan developmental alternative

Proposition

Development continues across the whole working life and is shaped by context, not fixed by birth year.

Mechanism

People change with age, experience, health, family stage and the time they see ahead of them.

Critique of generations

Generational accounts name groups but supply no mechanism linking birth year to behavior at work.

At Bharat Textiles

Ask what changed in BT 2026400 across 22.5 years, not which band he was born into.

Rudolph, C. W., and Zacher, H. (2017). Considering generations from a lifespan developmental perspective. Work, Aging and Retirement, 3(2), 113 to 129

Kooij et al. (2008): five meanings of age

Chronological	Functional	Psychosocial	Organizational	Lifespan
Calendar age	Performance, health, cognitive ability	How old one feels and is seen to be	Tenure, career stage, role age	Life events, family stage

Each meaning predicts different motives. A generational label collapses all five into the first.

Akkermans et al. (2016): once subjective age is measured, chronological age adds almost nothing to work motivation.

L1 · A MECHANISM FOR AGE

Socioemotional selectivity theory

Time seen as open ended

Goals favor knowledge, novelty, new contacts and future payoff

Growth, mobility, learning



Time seen as limited

Goals favor emotionally meaningful relationships and present meaning

Depth, mastery, generativity

The driver is perceived future time, not age itself. A layoff threat or an illness can shorten it at 30.

Carstensen, L. L., Isaacowitz, D. M., and Charles, S. T. (1999). Taking time seriously. American Psychologist, 54(3), 165 to 181

Kooij et al. (2011): age and work motives

Motive	Lifespan prediction	Meta analytic finding
Intrinsic	Rises with age	Significant positive relationship
Growth	Falls with age	Significant negative relationship
Extrinsic	Falls with age	Significant negative relationship
Security and social	Rise with age	Only in certain subgroups

A lifespan theory predicted the direction in advance. That is what a generational label has never done.

Selection, optimization and compensation

Selection

Narrow goals to a few that matter most, by choice or after a loss

Optimization

Invest time and effort to refine the means for those goals

Compensation

Find substitute means when a capacity declines

Design implication: let experienced employees select and deepen, rather than push them toward breadth they have chosen to give up.

Baltes, P. B., and Baltes, M. M. (1990). Successful Aging: Perspectives from the Behavioral Sciences. Cambridge University Press, 1 to 34

Stereotypes and the ecological fallacy

Ecological fallacy

Inferring an individual's attributes from a group correlation. A group average is not a fact about each member.

Robinson (1950)

Age stereotypes at work

Older workers seen as poorer performers, resistant to change, slower to learn, costlier. Evidence supports few of these.

Posthuma and Campion (2009)

A generational program institutionalizes both errors: it assigns a group average to every member, and it acts on beliefs the evidence does not support.

Robinson (1950), American Sociological Review, 15(3), 351 to 357; Posthuma and Campion (2009), Journal of Management, 35(1), 158 to 188

Same case, four theories, four designs

Theory	Why BT 2026400 declines a move	Design it implies
Generational (cohort)	Gen X values stability	A Gen X retention scheme
Socioemotional selectivity	Shorter horizon favors depth and meaning	Meaningful mastery work
Selection, optimization, compensation	Elective selection of a specialist domain	Specialist track, no mobility penalty
Organizational age (Kooij)	Late career stage in a role he has built	Stage based development conversation

L1 · COLD CALLS ON ROUND 4

Your Round 4 segments: which mechanism does each one target, and which theory licenses it?

Name the theory. Name the mechanism. Name the evidence that would prove you wrong.

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